EDITOR'S INTRODUCTION

"HUMANITARIAN" is a modern word coined to express a modern idea, and it is not to be found in Johnson's Dictionary. Life for the privileged classes in his day was a more comfortable business than it had ever been before, or has been since. Power rested with them alone, and to them everything seemed for the best, in the best possible constitution. The miseries of the unfortunate, on the other hand, were not readily evident owing to the poverty of communications. So it was that glaring evils and hideous cruelties flourished and multiplied with impunity.

It is true that here and there a Goldsmith or a Cowper made music out of his sympathy for the oppressed. But these merely flattered the sensibilities of their readers: to shatter their hard-headed complacence an exposure of some intolerable abuse was needed, in plain prose, by a man of exceptional tenacity and force of character.

The abuse existed in the two hundred odd prisons of the day. There the innocent and the guilty, men and girls, women and boys, were herded together to be enfeebled for life or starved, frozen, and rotted to death. There ill-conditioned gaolers urged their charges to debauchery, that they might share in the profits of its supply, and robbed acquitted felon and discharged debtor alike of liberty and life, in the hope of swelling their own gains. There filth, oppression, disease, and despair united to broadcast physical and moral corruption throughout the land.

The man came forward in John Howard, and it was from the pity and indignation kindled in him by his contact with prisons on his appointment as Sheriff of Bedford in 1773 that the torch of the Humanitarian Ideal was lit.

To any one then conversant with his previous life, he must have seemed a most unlikely person for the task. He was forty-seven—elderly for those days—in indifferent health, and something of a valetudinarian. He had twice married, his first wife, who died after three years, being his landlady, and fifty-two when he was twenty-five. He had had an indifferent education, being early apprenticed to a grocer, but had abandoned business entirely on succeeding to the